

DESIGNARE LIBRARY · RESOURCE 02

NO FLUFF.
JUST DATA.

BRUTAL
BUT
HONEST

the 8-second portfolio checklist

Audit your portfolio the same way a hiring manager would — before you send another application.

Subject: Thank you for
your application

Hi there,

Thank you for taking the
time to apply.

After careful
consideration, we've
decided to move forward
with other candidates.

Best regards,
The Hiring Team



PAIN >
PORTFOLIO
POLISH

312 REVIEWS · 41 HIRING MANAGERS · 2025

by designare



READ THIS FIRST

you don't have a portfolio problem.
you have an 8-second problem.

Hiring managers don't read portfolios. They **scan, judge, and decide** — then read only if they've already decided you're worth it.

WHAT THIS RESOURCE IS

A 9-section, 60-point audit built from what 41 hiring managers actually did when we put 312 real portfolios in front of them. Every check is something a reviewer noticed — not a "best practice" we made up.

WHAT IT IS NOT

A tutorial on building a portfolio. A template. A motivational document. If you want to *feel* good about your portfolio, close this. If you want to *know* why it's not converting, keep going.

THE ONE RULE

Everything in this checklist is scored against a single question a reviewer is silently asking: **"Can this person make my team's problem go away?"** Not "is this pretty." Not "did they follow a process." Can they make the problem go away.

HOW THE REVIEW ACTUALLY HAPPENS

TIME	WHAT THE REVIEWER DOES	WHAT THEY DECIDE
0–8 sec	Lands on homepage. Reads your role line. Glances at the first 2–3 thumbnails.	"Keep or close tab?"
8–60 sec	Opens the first case study. Skims headline, hero image, and any bold outcome.	"Junior, mid, or senior?"
1–4 min	Reads one case study properly. Checks decisions, trade-offs, results.	"Can they think?"
4–6 min	Opens About. Checks LinkedIn. Looks for red flags.	"Interview or reject?"

Median time-on-portfolio: 3m 42s. Median time to a rejection decision: 7.8 sec.

THE DATA

what 41 hiring managers
actually told us.

73%

REJECTED BEFORE
OPENING A CASE STUDY

7.8s

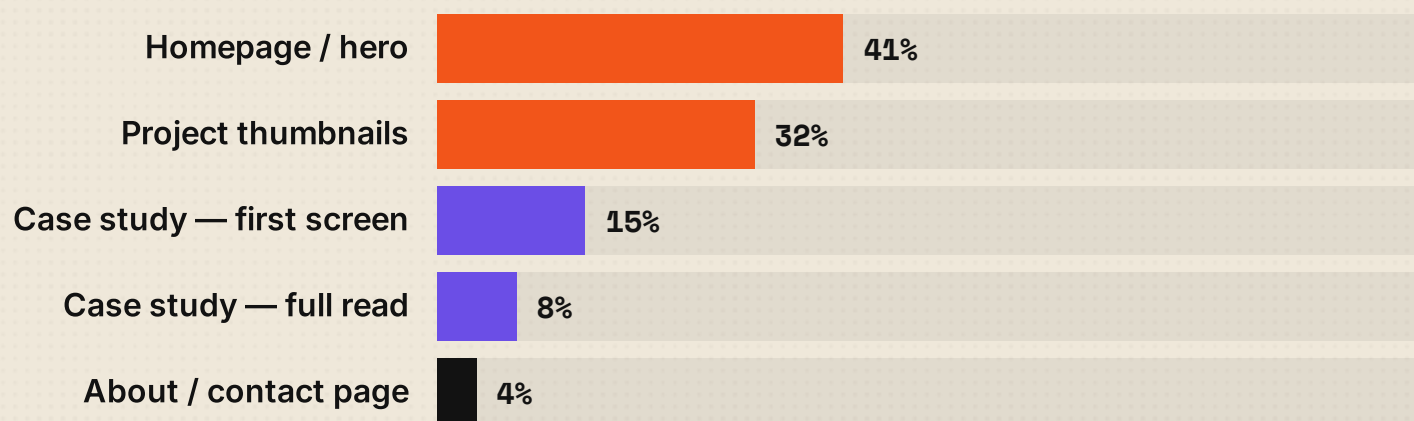
MEDIAN TIME TO
A "NO"

1.4

CASE STUDIES OPENED
PER REJECTED PORTFOLIO

WHERE THE DECISION HAPPENS

Share of final decisions made at each stage of the review (n = 312)



73% of decisions happen before a single case study is opened. Your case studies are defending a verdict that's already been reached.

"I'm not looking for reasons to hire. I'm looking for reasons to stop scrolling."

— Design Director, fintech, 60+ portfolios/month

↑ *read that twice. it's the whole game.*



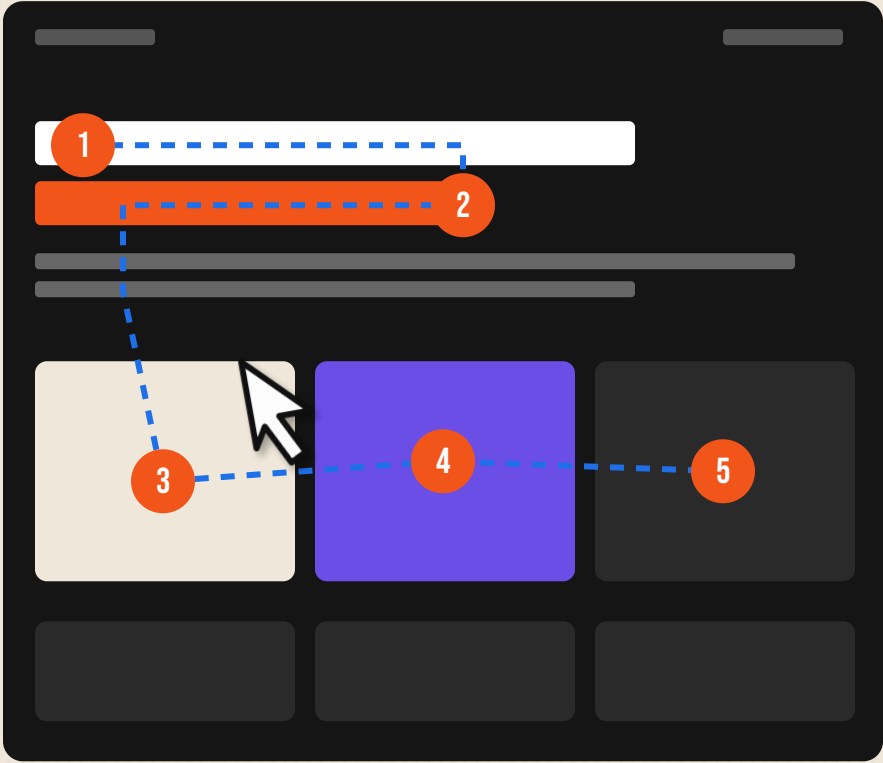
REJECTED

DIAGRAM 01

the
8-second scan path.



We tracked where reviewers looked first, second, and third on 312 homepages. The path is almost identical every time — and it never includes your intro paragraph.



- 1 • Name + role line
0.0 – 1.5 s • "What are you?"
- 2 • Who you've worked with
1.5 – 3.0 s • "Are you real?"
- 3 • First thumbnail
3.0 – 4.5 s • "Is this a product?"
- 4 • Second thumbnail
4.5 – 6.0 s • "Is it a pattern?"
- 5 • Third thumbnail → scroll or close
6.0 – 8.0 s • verdict

WHAT GETS SEEN

Role line • client/company names • first 3 thumbnails • one bold number if it's above the fold.

WHAT GETS SKIPPED

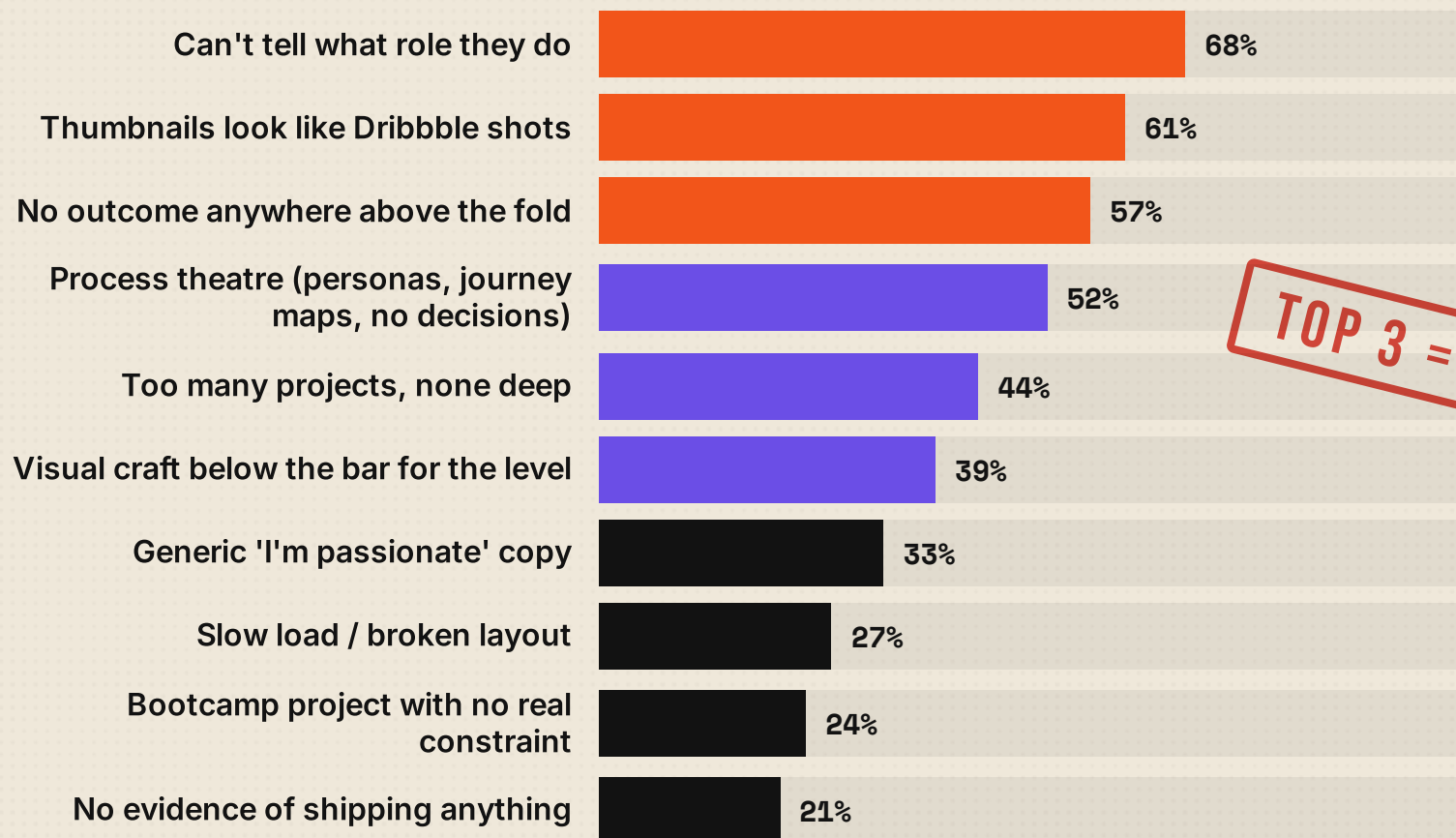
Your "I'm passionate about..." paragraph • animated intro • skills list • anything below thumbnail row 1.

the intro paragraph was fixated by 6% of reviewers. six.

THE DATA

top 10 reasons portfolios get rejected.

% of rejected portfolios where reviewers cited this reason (multiple reasons allowed, n = 228 rejections)



TOP 3 = CLARITY

Source: Designare Portfolio Review 2025. Reviewers rated each rejection against a fixed list of 18 reasons plus free text.

READ THE PATTERN, NOT THE LIST

The top 3 reasons are all **clarity** problems, not skill problems. Reviewers rejected people who were probably good — because the portfolio made them work to find out. Nobody works to find out.

HOW TO USE THIS

score it like
a stranger would.

Nine sections. Sixty points. One rule: if you have to argue that you deserve the point, you don't get the point.

0 POINTS

Fails. Not present, or present but a reviewer wouldn't find it in the time they'd actually spend.

1 POINT

Partial. It's there, but you'd have to point it out. Buried, vague, or inconsistent across projects.

2 POINTS

Obvious. A stranger scanning at speed would clock it without help. Every project, not just your best one.

THE PROTOCOL

- 01 **Don't audit your own portfolio first.** Hand this checklist to someone who's never seen it. Give them 8 seconds on the homepage, then 60 seconds on one case study. Score from *their* answers.
- 02 **Then audit it yourself** on a laptop you don't normally use, in an incognito window, with the timer running. Fresh cache exposes load-time problems you've stopped seeing.
- 03 **Score every project, not just the best one.** Reviewers open your weakest project as often as your strongest. Your score is your average, not your peak.
- 04 **Fill the scorecard on page 18,** then read the band you land in on page 19. Do the 30-minute fixes on page 20 before anything else.

SECTION 1-3 = FIRST 8 SECONDS

4-7 = THE 60-SECOND SKIM

8-9 = THE FULL READ

weighting is deliberate. sections 1-3 carry 40% of the points because they carry 73% of the decisions.





1

the first 8 seconds.

homepage & hero

10 POINTS · DECIDES 41% OF OUTCOMES

SECTION
1 OF 9



Your role is stated in the first line, in the words the job posting uses.

2 pts

"Product Designer" not "Designer & dreamer." Reviewers match your label to the req before anything else. 68% of rejections started here.



Your name + role + one proof point are visible without scrolling on a 13" laptop.

2 pts

Proof point = a company, a number, or a shipped product. One. Not a list.



The first 3 thumbnails are real products with real UI, not hero renders.

2 pts

Tilted 3D mockups on gradients read as "Dribbble" in 0.4s. Reviewers said the word "Dribbble" 61% of the time in rejections.



At least one outcome number is above the fold.

2 pts

"+18% checkout conversion" on a thumbnail label outperforms any tagline you've written. Any number beats no number.



There is no intro paragraph longer than two lines.

2 pts

6% of reviewers read it. Cut it, or make it one sentence that does the job of your role line better.

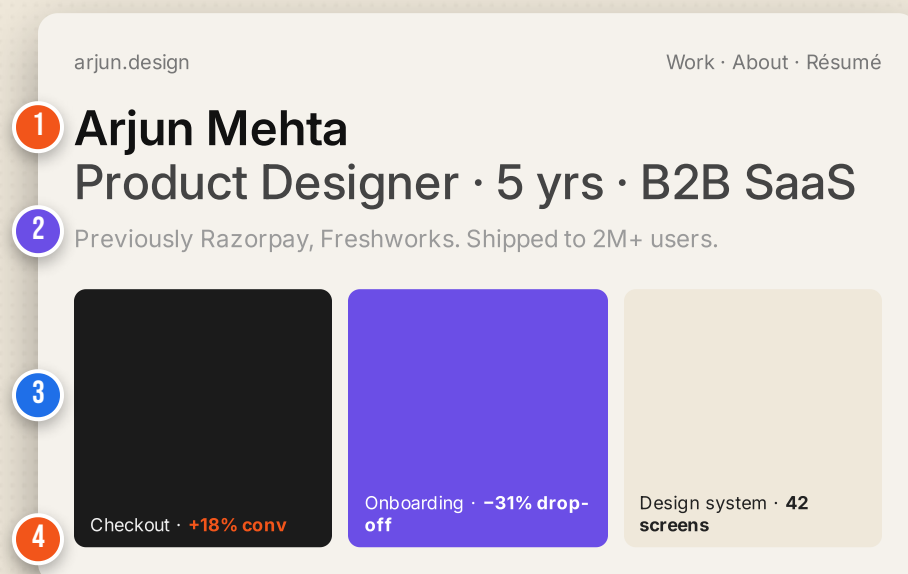
THE 8-SECOND TEST

Show your homepage to someone for 8 seconds. Close it. Ask: **"What does this person do, and what's one thing they've done?"** If they can't answer both, you scored 0–3 on this section regardless of how you scored yourself.



DIAGRAM 02

anatomy of a hero that survives 8 seconds.



- 1 Name + role + level + domain.**
One line. Four facts. The reviewer now knows if you're even in the right pile.
- 2 Proof line.**
Companies or scale. This answers "are you real?" in 1.5 seconds. No logos wall needed — names in text are faster to parse.
- 3 Real UI, cropped tight.**
Actual screens at actual density. No perspective tilt, no phone frame floating in space.
- 4 Outcome on the label.**
Project name + one number. The thumbnail now does the case study's job before the case study is opened.

KILL ON SIGHT

Full-screen animated intro · "Welcome to my portfolio" · scroll-jacked hero · a paragraph about your journey · a skills bar chart (Figma 90%, Sketch 80%...)

HM QUOTE

"If I can't tell your level from the hero, I assume junior and read everything through that lens."

— Head of Design, healthtech

2 project selection.

8 POINTS · FEWER, DEEPER, REAL

SECTION
2 OF 9

- ☐ **You show 3–5 projects. Not 8. Not 12.** 2 pts

Interview rate peaked at 3–4 projects and fell off a cliff after 6. Volume reads as "couldn't decide what's good."
- ☐ **Every project has a real constraint: real users, real business, real deadline, or real engineering limits.** 2 pts

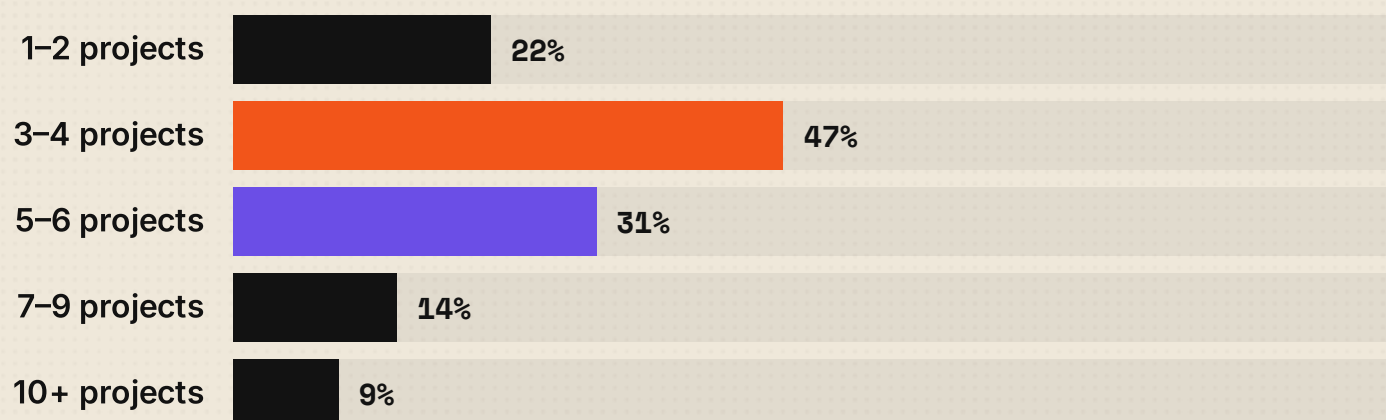
A redesign of Spotify with no constraint is a visual exercise. Reviewers rejected unconstrained concept work 24% of the time on that reason alone.
- ☐ **At least one project shipped, and you say so explicitly.** 2 pts

"Live since March 2025" or "in production at 40k users" — with a link if you can. Shipping is the single biggest senior/junior tell.
- ☐ **Your first project is your strongest, and it matches the job you're applying for.** 2 pts

Reviewers open project #1 in 84% of sessions. Reorder per application if you have to. It takes four minutes.

PROJECTS SHOWN VS. INTERVIEW RATE

% of portfolios that received an interview recommendation, by number of projects on the homepage (n = 312)



3–4 projects converted at 5× the rate of 10+. Every project you add past four is a project you're asking the reviewer to ignore on your behalf.

3–4 WINS

3 titles & thumbnails.

6 POINTS · THE THUMBNAIL IS THE PITCH

- ☐ Every project title says what changed, not what it is. 2 pts

"Redesigning checkout for a 2-step flow" beats "Checkout Redesign." Titles were the #2 most-fixated element on homepages.
- ☐ Every thumbnail shows the actual product, at readable size, on a plain background. 2 pts

If a reviewer can't tell what the product does from the thumbnail, the thumbnail failed.
- ☐ Thumbnails are consistent — same crop, same ratio, same treatment. 2 pts

Inconsistency reads as low craft before a single screen is opened. This is the cheapest 2 points in the document.

TITLE REWRITES FROM THE REVIEW

REJECTED	REWRITTEN
Food Delivery App	→ Cutting order abandonment 23% on a food delivery checkout
Fintech Dashboard UX	→ Getting SMB owners to reconcile daily instead of monthly
Design System	→ A component library that cut design-to-dev handoff from 9 days to 2
Healthcare App Case Study	→ Redesigning appointment booking for 60+ patients on 3G
EdTech Platform Redesign	→ Why we removed the dashboard and lifted lesson completion 2×

THE FORMULA

[verb] + [thing that changed] + [for whom / under what constraint]. If you don't have a number yet, use the constraint. "For 60+ patients on 3G" is more interesting than any adjective.

a title with a number gets opened. a title with an adjective gets scrolled past.



4 case study structure.

8 POINTS · BUILT TO BE SKIMMED

SECTION
4 OF 9

- ☐ The first screen of every case study has: title, one-line outcome, your role, timeline, and a hero image.

2 pts

That's the whole case study for 62% of reviewers. Everything below is for the 38% who liked what they saw.

- ☐ Section headings tell the story on their own.

2 pts

Read only your H2s. If they read "Research · Ideation · Wireframes · Final Designs", you've described a process, not a project.

- ☐ The result appears twice: at the top, and at the bottom.

2 pts

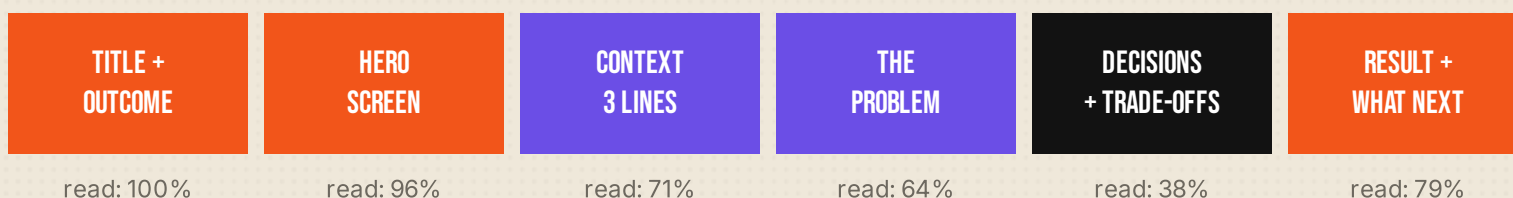
Reviewers skip to the end. If the number is only at the end, the top looks like it has no result.

- ☐ Every case study is readable in under 4 minutes at a skim.

2 pts

Measured, not guessed. 3,000+ words with 40 images is not "thorough", it's unread.

DIAGRAM 03 · THE 60-SECOND SKIM MAP



reviewers jump from the hero straight to the result, then decide whether to read the middle

Section read-rates from 84 full case-study reads

SO WHAT

Write the top and the bottom first. Make them agree. Then write the middle as evidence for a verdict the reviewer has already reached — because that's the order it gets read in.

5 outcomes & evidence.

8 POINTS · THE SENIOR / JUNIOR LINE

SECTION
5 OF 9

☐ Every project has a stated result — a number, a shipped state, or a clear "here's what we learned and killed."
"It launched" is a result. "Leadership loved it" is not. "We tested it, it lost, here's why" is a great result.

2 pts

☐ Every number has a baseline and a timeframe.
"+18% conversion" means nothing. "From 2.1% to 2.5% over 6 weeks post-launch, n=40k sessions" means you understand measurement.

2 pts

☐ You name at least one decision you made that someone disagreed with, and what happened.
This is the single strongest senior signal in the data. Reviewers cited it unprompted in 71% of "strong hire" notes.

2 pts

☐ You're honest about what you'd change. Specifically.
"With more time I'd do more research" is filler. "I'd have killed the onboarding carousel a sprint earlier — the data was there by week 2" is judgment.

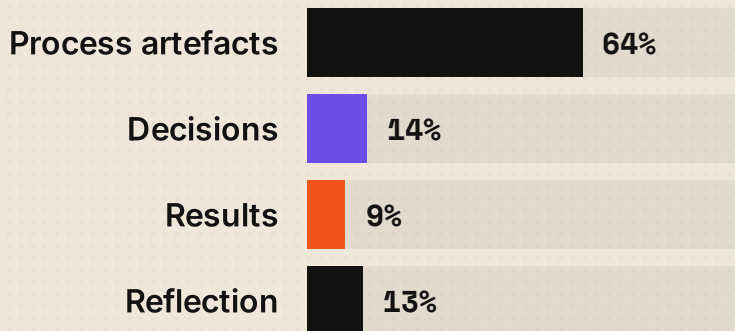
2 pts

SHOW THE FIGHT

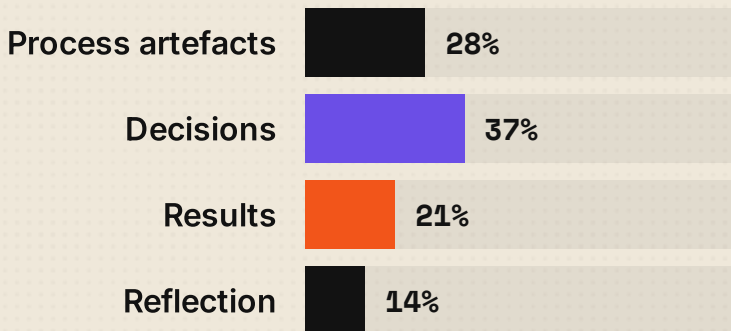
PROCESS VS. DECISIONS VS. RESULTS — WHAT THE PAGE IS MADE OF

Average share of case-study content by type, split by reviewer verdict (n = 84 full reads)

REJECTED



STRONG HIRE



Strong-hire case studies spent 2.6× more space on decisions and 2.3× more on results. Same length. Different ratio.



6 visual craft

8 POINTS · CRAFT IS READ IN 0.3 SECONDS

SECTION
6 OF 9

- ☐ **One spacing scale, used everywhere. Screens and the portfolio itself.**

2 pts

4/8/16/24/32/48/64. If a reviewer can spot a 13px gap next to a 17px gap, they've stopped trusting your screens.

- ☐ **A type system with no more than 4 sizes and 2 weights on any given screen.**

2 pts

Craft rejections (39%) were mostly typography. Five weights is not hierarchy, it's noise.

- ☐ **Your UI screens are shown at 1:1 or larger, and text in them is legible.**

2 pts

If a reviewer has to zoom to read your UI, they won't. They'll assume it's bad.

- ☐ **Real content, not lorem ipsum, not placeholders, not "John Doe."**

2 pts

Placeholder content is the fastest way to signal you never got near a real product.

- ☐ **The portfolio site itself is designed to the same bar as the work inside it.**

2 pts

A Product Designer with a broken mobile portfolio has told the reviewer exactly how much they QA.

THE SQUINT TEST

Squint at any screen until you can't read the text. You should still see clear hierarchy: one thing biggest, one thing second, everything else quiet. If it flattens into grey, the hierarchy was never there.

"I don't check craft. I notice when it's missing. Those are very different things."

— Principal Designer, e-commerce

8PX GRID OR GO HOME

7 writing & clarity.

6 POINTS · WRITE LIKE YOU TALK IN A STANDUP

- ☐
- No sentence in your portfolio contains: passionate, journey, delightful, seamless, user-centric, or leverage.**
- 2 pts

Present in 33% of rejections. These words tell the reviewer you learned to write portfolios from other portfolios.

- ☐
- Every paragraph is under 4 lines, and every case study opens with a sentence a 12-year-old could repeat back.**
- 2 pts

"We rebuilt checkout because 1 in 4 people quit at the address step." Done.

- ☐
- You use "I" for what you did and "we" for what the team did — and the split is visible.**
- 2 pts

Reviewers hunt for this. All-"we" case studies got asked "so what did *you* do?" in 100% of debriefs.



THE REJECTED-PHRASES LIST

Phrases reviewers flagged as "tells" — and what to write instead

THEY READ THIS AS...	WRITE THIS INSTEAD
I'm passionate about solving problems "Has never had to solve a hard one"	I've shipped 3 checkout flows. Two worked.
Crafting delightful experiences "Visual designer who doesn't measure"	Product designer, B2B payments, 5 yrs.
We conducted extensive user research "Six interviews and a survey"	12 interviews, 2 things surprised us: ...
The client was very happy with the result "No result was measured"	Live since March. Support tickets on this flow down 40%.
Leveraging a user-centric approach "AI wrote this"	We watched 8 people fail at step 3, so we deleted it.

if it sounds like a LinkedIn headline, it's not a case study.



8

about & contact

4 POINTS · THE LAST CHECK BEFORE 'INTERVIEW'

SECTION
8 OF 9



Your About page says where you've worked, for how long, and what you want next — in that order.

2 pts

Reviewers open About in the final 90 seconds to check for a mismatch with the role. Make the match obvious.

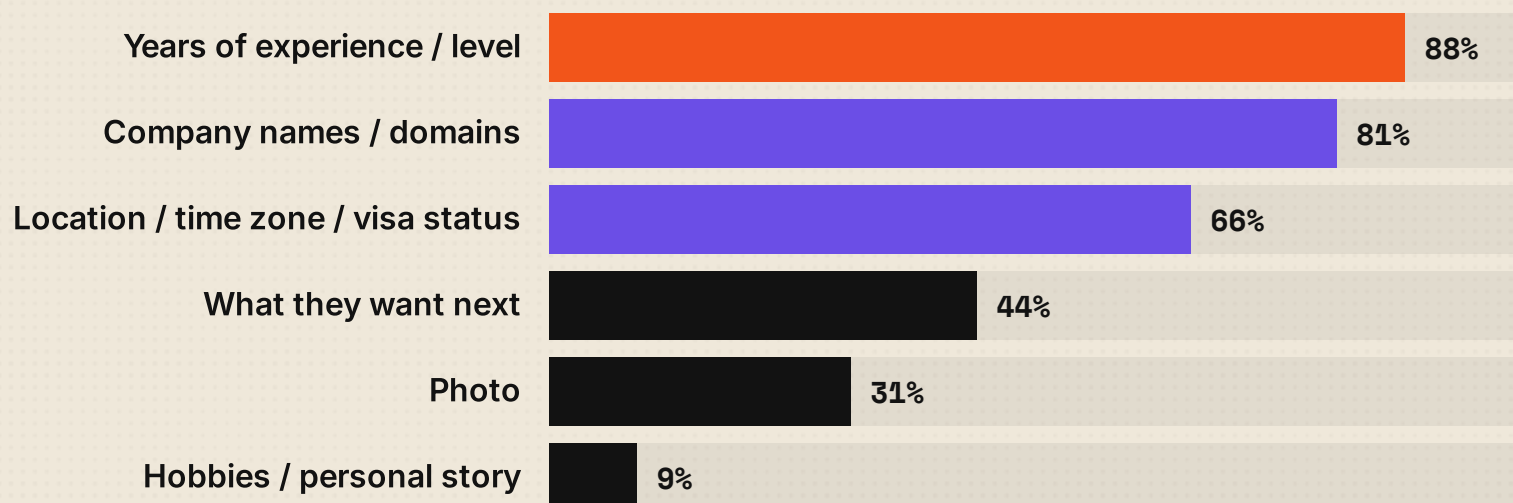


Email is visible as text on every page. Not just a form. Not just a LinkedIn icon.

2 pts

27% of reviewers who wanted to reach out abandoned when it took more than one click. A form is friction. Text is not.

WHAT REVIEWERS ACTUALLY LOOK FOR ON ABOUT



"Tell us about yourself" is not the brief. The brief is: "confirm you're the person the homepage promised."

FOUR LINES, THAT'S IT

Line 1: Level + domain + years.

Line 2: Where (companies), and the biggest thing you shipped there.

Line 3: What you're good at that the work above proves.

Line 4: What you want next + where you are + email.

CUT

Your origin story · "I believe design is..." · a manifesto · tool logos · "Currently learning" lists · testimonials from classmates · a downloadable PDF résumé that's out of date.

9 technical & performance.

2 POINTS · FAST OR FORGOTTEN

SECTION
9 OF 9

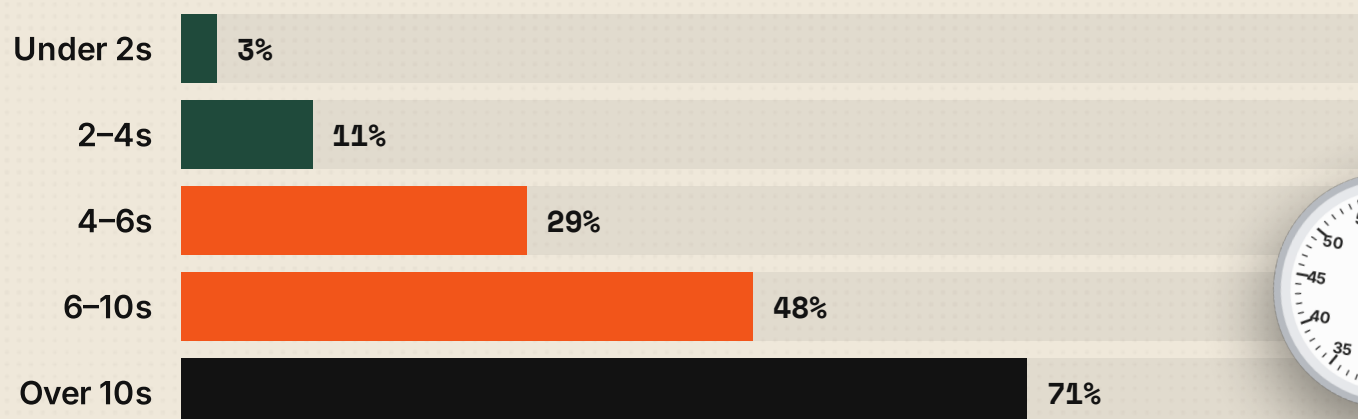
- ☐ Homepage loads in under 3 seconds on a throttled connection, and every link works.

2 pts

Test it in an incognito tab with network throttling set to 'Fast 3G'. 27% of rejections cited load or breakage. That's a checklist item costing people interviews.

LOAD TIME VS. BOUNCE BEFORE THE HERO IS SEEN

% of reviewers who closed the tab before the hero rendered, by homepage load time (n = 312)



Past 4 seconds, your portfolio starts failing before anyone has seen it. The 8-second clock starts on load, not on render.

THE 10-MINUTE TECHNICAL PASS

- ☐ Images compressed and sized — no 4MB PNGs, no 3000px hero for a 900px slot. Use WebP where you can.
- ☐ Mobile checked on a real phone, not the browser's device emulator. Reviewers opened 22% of portfolios on mobile first.
- ☐ Every external link opens; every Figma/Notion embed is public; no "Request access" screens.
- ☐ No password walls on your best project. If it's NDA, write the case study without the screens — reviewers respect that more than a locked door.
- ☐ Custom domain, HTTPS, and a favicon. Small things that read as "finished."



INSTANT REJECTION TRIGGERS

DO NOT SEND

things that end the review in under 3 seconds.

These aren't on the scorecard. They're worse. Any one of them can zero out a 55-point portfolio. Reviewers named them unprompted.

01 · UNCREDITED TEAM WORK

Presenting a 6-person project as yours. Reviewers check LinkedIn. It takes them 40 seconds and it's fatal.

05 · A PERSONA WITH A STOCK PHOTO

"Sarah, 34, busy mom." Instantly reads as process theatre. Cut personas unless you interviewed the people in them.

02 · REDESIGNS OF FAMOUS APPS WITH NO BRIEF

"Spotify, reimagined." Nobody asked. Shows you can't find a real problem.

06 · NO ROLE STATED, ANYWHERE

Not on the homepage, not on the case study, not on About. Reviewer has no idea what pile you go in.

03 · THE SAME BOOTCAMP PROJECT AS 400 OTHERS

Reviewers see the same brief weekly. Yours needs a constraint the brief didn't give you.

07 · "COMING SOON" ON MORE THAN ONE PROJECT

One is a work in progress. Two is a portfolio that isn't finished. Hide them.

04 · AI-GENERATED CASE STUDY COPY

They can tell. The tell is that every sentence is the same length and nothing is specific.

08 · A LOCKED PORTFOLIO WITH NO PREVIEW

Password on the homepage = closed tab. Every time. Put the password in your application if you must, but show something first.

a red flag doesn't lower your score. it means nobody counts it.



SCORE OUT OF 60

THE SCORECARD

print this. fill it in.
do it twice.

Column A: a stranger's score after 8 seconds + 60 seconds. Column B: your own score, incognito, timer running. If A and B differ by more than 10 points, trust A.

SECTION		MAX	A · STRANGER	B · YOU
1	Homepage & hero	/ 10		
2	Project selection	/ 8		
3	Titles & thumbnails	/ 6		
4	Case study structure	/ 8		
5	Outcomes & evidence	/ 8		
6	Visual craft	/ 8		
7	Writing & clarity	/ 6		
8	About & contact	/ 4		
9	Technical & performance	/ 2		
TOTAL		/ 60		

RED FLAGS PRESENT?

- ☐ 01
- ☐ 02
- ☐ 03
- ☐ 04
- ☐ 05
- ☐ 06
- ☐ 07
- ☐ 08

Any box ticked → fix before scoring means anything.

THE STRANGER'S ANSWERS

What does this person do?

Name one thing they've done:

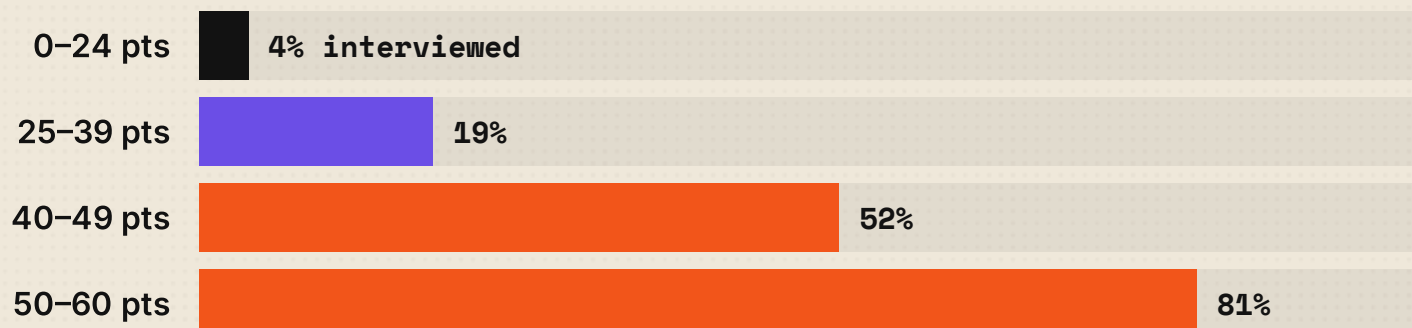
date: _____ · portfolio version: _____ · re-audit in 30 days

81%
AT 50+

WHAT YOUR SCORE MEANS

the four bands. and what to do in each.

Interview-recommendation rate by audit score band, applied retrospectively to the 312 reviewed portfolios



0-24

NOT READY. STOP APPLYING.

Every application you send from here trains recruiters to skip your name. Rebuild sections 1-3 first. Two weeks, three projects, then re-audit.

25-39

FIXABLE IN A WEEKEND.

You have the work; the portfolio hides it. Do the 30-minute fixes (next page), then rewrite every title and every first screen. Most of the 312 sat here.

40-49

COMPETITIVE. NOW SHARPEN.

You'll get interviews at mid-level. To move up, the gap is almost always section 5: decisions, trade-offs, and honest results. Add one fight to each case study.

50-60

SEND IT. THEN STOP TOUCHING IT.

Portfolio is not your bottleneck anymore. Interview prep and targeting are. Re-audit only when you ship something new.

most people who ask "is my portfolio good enough?" are in the 25-39 band. it's good. it's just hidden.



EXECUTION

the 30-minute fix plan.

Ordered by points recovered per minute. Do these before anything else, in this order, tonight.

TIME	FIX	RECOVERS
4 min	Rewrite your role line to match the job title in the posting. Add level + domain. Delete the intro paragraph.	up to 6 pts
6 min	Cut to your best 4 projects. Move the rest to a "More work" page or delete them. Put the most relevant one first.	up to 6 pts
8 min	Rewrite every project title using [verb] + [what changed] + [constraint]. Add a number to each thumbnail label if you have one.	up to 6 pts
5 min	Put the result at the top of every case study. One line, under the title. Copy it from the bottom if it's only there.	up to 4 pts
3 min	Add email as text to the header or footer of every page. Add years + companies to line 1 of About.	up to 4 pts
4 min	Find-and-delete passionate, journey, delightful, seamless, user-centric, leverage. Rewrite the sentence or cut it.	up to 2 pts

Portfolios in the 25-39 band that applied only these six fixes re-scored at a mean of 44 – moving from a 19% to a 52% interview band.

THIS WEEKEND (THE NEXT 15 POINTS)

- 01 Rebuild the first screen of each case study to the anatomy on page 8. Title, outcome, role, timeline, hero.
- 02 Add one "decision someone disagreed with" section per case study. 4-6 lines. What, why, what happened.
- 03 Rewrite every H2 so the headings tell the story alone. Then delete any section a heading can't justify.
- 04 Replace every tilted mockup with a flat, cropped, 1:1 screen. Re-export thumbnails at one ratio.
- 05 Run the technical pass on page 16. Then re-audit with a stranger.

6 minutes.
every application.
no exceptions.

THE PRE-SEND RITUAL

before you send another application.

Six minutes. Every time. This is the difference between applying and being considered.

- ☐ **Reorder projects so #1 matches this job's domain and level.**
Four minutes of effort. Reviewers open project #1 in 84% of sessions. Make it the one they'd want.
- ☐ **Read the job posting's title and first three requirements. Are those words on your homepage?**
If the req says 'B2B SaaS, design systems, 4+ yrs' and your hero says 'creative technologist', you've already lost the match.
- ☐ **Open your portfolio in incognito on your phone. Load it. Count.**
If you get past 3 before the hero renders, fix it before sending.
- ☐ **Run the 8-second test on yourself. Timer on. Homepage. Close. Say your role and one outcome aloud.**
If you hesitate, they will too.
- ☐ **Check every link in the application email opens to a public page.**
One 'Request access' screen and the reviewer has moved to the next candidate.
- ☐ **Cut the cover letter to three lines: role, the one project that proves it, a link.**
Reviewers read cover letters 11% of the time. A short one gets read. A long one gets your portfolio pre-judged.

THE THREE-LINE APPLICATION

Line 1: "Product designer, 5 yrs, B2B payments — applying for [role]."

Line 2: "Most relevant: [project title with number] — [link]."

Line 3: "Full portfolio: [link]. Email: [email]. Based in [city]."

you don't need a better portfolio for every job. you need the same portfolio, pointed at the job.

resources for designers who'd rather **know than hope.**

Every resource in this library is built the same way: real reviews, real hiring managers, real numbers. No frameworks invented on a whiteboard. No fluff.

IN THE SERIES

01	How Portfolios Get Rejected in 8 Seconds — the study.	released
02	The 8-Second Portfolio Checklist — this document.	you are here
03	The Case Study Autopsy — 20 real case studies, annotated by the people who rejected them.	next
04	Junior vs. Senior: The Portfolio Tells — the 14 signals reviewers use to place your level.	soon
05	The Design Systems Portfolio — how to show systems work when the work is invisible.	soon

ONE ASK

Audit your portfolio with this. Get your score. Then fix it and score it again. If it moved, tell us the before and after — we're building the next study from what actually works.

MORE
RESOURCES
COMING

DESIGNARE

Industry-ready designers.
Design systems · Product thinking · Visual
craft.

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